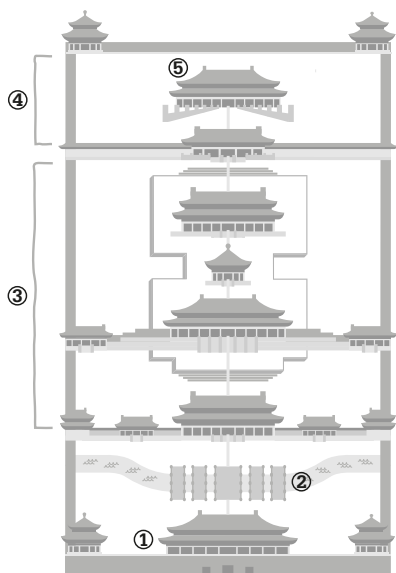


The Forbidden City—the imperial palace in Beijing—adhered to hierarchic Confucian ideology: the higher one's social status, the further one could enter into the city.



1 Meridian Gate The grand entrance had five gates. The central one was always reserved for the emperor.

2 The Golden Water Bridge Crossing points like the bridges were arranged in odd numbers. Only the emperor could use the central passage, with the next highest rank able to use the neighboring paths.

3 Outer Court This area was reserved for state affairs and ceremonial purposes.

4 Inner Court Only the emperor and his family could enter the Inner Court.

5 The Palace of Heavenly Purity To fool assassins, the palace had nine bedrooms: the emperor slept in a different one each night.

to the six ministries and other government agencies—the Ming retained a more autocratic and highly centralized structure than that of previous Chinese dynasties. This was reflected in the protocol of the Ming court, too: under the Song dynasty (960–1279), the emperor's advisers had stood

before him to discuss matters of state, but under the Ming they were required to *kowtow*—kneel and knock their heads to the floor—before him, a reverential acknowledgment of his absolute power and superiority.

Curbing the military

In the later years of the Yuan dynasty, the state had been torn apart by competing power bases outside the central court, and in a bid to avoid this scenario, Hongwu diluted the strength of the army. Although he adopted the Yuan military system—establishing garrisons in key cities, particularly along the northern frontier, where the threat of nomad incursions was ever-present, and creating a hereditary caste of soldiers that supported itself on land granted by the government—he also ensured that military units were periodically rotated through the capital for training, and that a group of centrally selected officers shared authority in the army with the garrison commanders, thus preventing the rise of influential warlords with a strong local base.

Perfecting the civil service

Hongwu also had a deep mistrust of the elite scholar class that had been at the heart of government for centuries. However, he was aware that they played a vital role in the efficient running of the state, and so he promoted education and trained scholars specifically for the bureaucracy. In 1373, he suspended the traditional examinations used to recruit civil servants and ordered the establishment of local county and prefectural schools. From these, the best candidates would be called for further study at a national university in the capital, where eventually 10,000 students from the original intake were enrolled. The civil service examinations were restored in 1385, when the emperor considered the well-trained graduates of the university ready to take them, and were so competitive that soldiers were stationed outside the cubicles where the examinees sat to avoid any collaboration or illicit use of reference materials.